

Session 27: Cain Fails His Test

Key Takeaways

- The blood of the innocent crying out to God from the ground is a key motif in the biblical narrative that moves God to action.
- The actions of Cain align him with the “seed of the snake” not the “seed of the woman.”

Yahweh’s Dialogue With Cain: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 4:8-16

Yahweh’s Dialogue With Cain

- a 8 and **Cain** spoke to **Abel** his brother
b and it came about when they were in the field,
a' and **Cain** rose up to **Abel** his brother
b' and he **killed** him.
a 9 and **Yahweh said to Cain,**
b **"Where is Abel your brother?"**
a' and he said,
b' "I do not know. Am I the keeper of **my brother?**"

- 10 **and he said**
"What have you done?"
a **The voice of the shed-blood of your brother**
b is crying out to me **from the ground** .
b' 11 and now, you are cursed **from the ground** .
a' which **has opened its mouth**
a' to receive **the shed-blood of your brother** from your hand.

- 12 When you work **the ground** ,
it will no longer yield its strength to you;
you will be a vagrant and a wanderer in the land."

- 13 and **Cain** said to the Lord,
a "My punishment is too great to lift up,
b 14 Behold, You have banished me this day

c from the face of the ground ;
c' and from your face I will be hidden,
b' and I will be a vagrant and a wanderer in the land ,
a' and whoever finds me will kill me ."

15 and Yahweh said to him, "
"Therefore whoever, kill Cain
seven times he will be avenged,"
and Yahweh established a sign for Cain ,

so that anyone who finds him would not strike him .
16 and Cain went out from the face of Yahweh ,
and he dwelt in the land of Wandering/Nod , east of Eden.

The Cain and Abel Story. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

Yahweh's words to Cain turn his anger into a moment of testing that is modeled closely on the story of his parents' testing and failure.

The Blood Cries Out

In Genesis 4:10-4:11, God tells Cain that the voice of his brother's blood is crying out from the ground. Notice that the ground has become an active character (it "cries" and "opens its mouth" and "receives") that witnesses Abel's murder, is defiled by it, and testifies as a witness.

Humanity was made from clay made by water and dust ([Gen. 2:7](#)), but now a human returns to the dirt in the form of blood, which results not in the ground being cursed but Cain being cursed from the ground.

This begins an important design pattern throughout the Hebrew Bible, related to the "city of bloodshed." When human societies build themselves upon the blood of the innocent, God hears their cry and responds.

Genesis 6:13 NASB

Then God said to Noah, "The end of all flesh **has come before me**; for the earth is filled with **violence** because of them; and behold, I am about to destroy them with the earth.

The Land

Genesis 18:20-21 NASB

²⁰ And the Lord said, "The **outcry of Sodom and Gomorrah** is indeed great, and their sin is exceedingly grave. ²¹ I will go down now, and see if they have done entirely according to **its outcry, which has come to me**; and if not, I will know."

Sodom

Exodus 2:23 NASB

Now it came about in the course of those many days that the king of Egypt died. And the sons of Israel sighed because of the bondage, and they cried out; and **their cry for help because of their bondage rose up to God.**

Egypt

God Shows Mercy and Gives a Sign

In Genesis 4:13-4:14, Cain complains of the severity of the consequences and then blames God for his exile. Cain also raises the important factor that he has blood on his hands and that an “avenger of blood” may “find” him and exact justice. His language hints forward to the kinsman redeemer, whose family responsibility it was to avenge the murder of a relative (Num. 35:12-25).

God “sets a sign for Cain” (not “on” him). The history of interpretation for this verse is littered with imaginative speculations that are not grounded in the text. The earliest collection of interpretations is found in an early Jewish commentary on Genesis (4th-6th century A.D.) called *Genesis Rabbah* (Ginzberg, Louis, [The Legends of the Jews](#), p. 107).

Seven Interpretive Opinions on the Sign of Cain

1. God caused the sun to rise (as a sign that Cain was not to be slain by animals)
2. He marked him by inflicting leprosy on him
3. He gave him a dog to protect him against animals
4. He marked him with a horn on his forehead (as a degradation of his human form)
5. He punished Cain as a sign (warning) to future murderers
6. He partly pardoned his sin as a sign (example) for future sinners who repent
7. He allowed him to live until the flood

The Sign Motif

The “sign for Cain” begins a design pattern motif in the Hebrew Bible. When God confronts humanity’s evil, he usually brings justice while also showing mercy. And he marks this distinction by means of a sign (’ot / אות), a symbol that itself communicates the meaning of the event on a deep level.

Genesis 9:11-15 NASB*

¹¹ “I set up my covenant with you; and all flesh shall never again be cut off by the water of the flood, neither shall there again be a flood to ruin the earth.” ¹² And Elohim said, “This is the sign of the covenant, which I am giving between me and you and every living creature that is with you, for all successive generations; ¹³ I give my bow in the cloud, and it shall be for a **sign** of a covenant between me and the earth. ¹⁴ It shall come about, when I bring a cloud over the earth, that the bow will be seen in the cloud, ¹⁵ and I will remember my covenant, which is between me and you and every living creature of all flesh and never again shall the water become a flood to ruin all flesh.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The rainbow is a sign of God's judgment and rescue.

Genesis 17:10-14 NASB

¹⁰ "This is my covenant, which you shall keep, between me and you and your seed after you: every male among you shall be circumcised. ¹¹ And you shall be circumcised in the flesh of your foreskin, and it shall be the **sign** of the covenant between me and you. ¹² And every male among you who is eight days old shall be circumcised throughout your generations, a servant who is born in the house or who is bought with money from any foreigner, who is not of your seed ... thus shall my covenant be in your flesh for an everlasting covenant. ¹⁴ But an uncircumcised male who is not circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin, that person shall be cut off from his people; he has broken my covenant."

Circumcision is a sign of God's judgment and his eternal promise to raise up a seed for Abraham.

Exodus 8:21-24 NASB

²¹ "For if you do not let my people go, behold, I will send swarms of flies on you and on your servants and on your people and into your houses ... ²² But on that day I will set apart the land of Goshen, where my people are living, so that no swarms of flies will be there, in order that you may know that I, the Lord, am in the midst of the land. ²³ I will set a division between my people and your people. Tomorrow this **sign** will occur." ²⁴ Then the Lord did so. And there came great swarms of flies into the house of Pharaoh and the houses of his servants and the land was ruined because of the swarms of flies in all the land of Egypt.

Exodus 10:1-2 NASB

¹ Then Yahweh said to Moses, "Go to Pharaoh, for I have hardened his heart and the heart of his servants, that I may set my **signs** among them, ² and that you may tell in the hearing of your son, and of your grandson, how I made a mockery of the Egyptians and how I set my signs among them, that you may know that I am the Lord."

The plagues that God sends on Egypt are signs of God's judgment and his commitment to save the Israelites (see also [Ps. 78:43](#); [105:27](#)). God also gives a sign of the distinction between Egypt and Israel.

Exodus 12:12-13 NASB

¹² For I will go through the land of Egypt on that night, and will strike all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, both human and beast; and against all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgments. I am Yahweh. ¹³ The blood shall be a **sign** for you on the houses where you live; and when I see the blood I will pass over you, and there will be on you no plague to ruin you when I strike the land of Egypt.

The blood of the passover lamb on the doorposts is a sign of God's judgment and mercy.

Joshua 2:12-13 NIV

¹² Now then, please swear to me by the Lord that you will show kindness to my family, because I have shown kindness to you. Give me a **sign**, a reliable one ¹³ that you will preserve the lives of my father and

mother, my brothers and sisters, and all who belong to them—and that you will deliver us from death.

Joshua 2:17-19 NIV

¹⁷ Now the men had said to her, “This oath you made us swear will not be binding on us ¹⁸ unless, when we enter the land, you have tied this **cord of scarlet** thread in the window through which you let us down, and unless you have brought your father and mother, your brothers and all your family into your house (הביתה).

¹⁹ If any of them go outside your house into the street, their blood will be on their own heads; we will not be responsible. As for those who are in the house with you, their blood will be on our head if a hand is laid on them.”

Rahab's scarlet cords in Jericho are a sign for God to spare her family when he brings his judgment on the city.

Cain's sign is the archetype of all these “signs of sparing.” In each instance, Yahweh could strike and bring ruin indiscriminately, but instead, he makes his mercy available to a remnant, showing his mercy with a visual sign.

The story that sets up this design pattern does not tell us what the sign is but only what it means: that Cain stands under God's judgment for his murder, and no one else has the legal or moral right to exact vengeance on him. But Cain also stands under God's mercy, which is marked by “a sign for Cain.”

This is a good example of how design patterns work in the Hebrew Bible. In this case, the first appearance of a motif is the most ambiguous, and it is only through repetition that the motif gains clarity. Notice that all of the signs are visual phenomena (bow in the sky, cutting of flesh, blood on door frame, cord of scarlet thread on window).

It's also possible that in [Genesis 4:15](#), we are given the content of the sign in the form of Yahweh's declaration of protection for Cain.

“[T]he meaning is not: whoever slays Cain will be punished seven times as much as one who kills any other person; such a penalty would not be in accord with justice. Seven [שבע, *šebha*] is the number of completeness (see Genesis 1); and שבעתים *šibhāthayim*—that is, seven times—connotes in complete measure, with the full stringency of the law. Compare Psalm 12:6 ‘gold that is purified seven times;’ or Psalm 79:12 ‘return sevenfold into the bosom of our neighbors.’ The one who slays Cain will deserve to be punished with the utmost severity, because he will be guilty of a dual offense: the crime of shedding blood, and the sin of contemning the Lord's judgement by augmenting the divine punishment.”

Cassuto, U. (1961). [A Commentary on the Book of Genesis \(Part I\): from Adam to Noah](#). Magnes Press.

It is Yahweh's verdict that the first human murderer, who should experience just consequences, is instead spared. This, Yahweh says, is “a sign for Cain.” If Yahweh, who has full rights to eliminate Cain, does not do so, there is no right for anyone else to kill him. This is a potent sign: Yahweh does not want to take away life.

This interpretation has the advantage of taking on board the meaning of all the future signs of mercy that repeat the design pattern. But it has the disadvantage of not being a visual cue, which all the later signs are.

“The precise nature of the sign remains uncertain, but its function is clear. As the clothing given to Adam and Eve after the fall (Gen. 3:21) served to remind them of their sin and God's mercy, so does

the mark placed on Cain. As a protective device against potential enemies it may stay death; in that sense, the anticipated punishment is softened. But at the same time it serves as a constant reminder of Cain's banishment, his isolation from other people."

Wenham, Gordon J. (1987). [Genesis 1-15 \(Word Biblical Commentary\)](#). Thomas Nelson Inc.

God's Mercy, Cain's Wife, and Cain's City

Immediately after God provides a protective sign for Cain, he "went out from before the face of Yahweh, and he settled in the land of "wandering (*nod* /נוֹד), east of Eden" ([Gen. 4:16](#)). That is, he leaves the scene of 4:1-16, outside the "door" of the garden, and he leaves Eden and his family.

Outside of Eden, Cain does two things that surprise the reader that may have assumed Adam and Eve were the only or first human beings. He impregnates his wife (where did she come from?), and he builds a city (for whom?!). What's going on here?

Cain's Wife

While no other siblings of Cain or Abel are mentioned in the story, we do learn in [Genesis 5:4](#) that Adam and Eve did have other sons and daughters after Cain and Abel. But it is not likely that we are meant to think that Cain married one of his sisters. His exile from Eden is also an exile from his family. This seems to be the whole point of his punishment—isolation ("a vagrant and wanderer you will be," Gen. 4:12). Instead of assuming that Cain is going into a world empty of humans, this detail is one of the main indicators that Genesis 2:4-3:24 is an archetypal account of the first human priests, not of the first humans on Earth. In that case, Cain is returning to the humanity from which his parents were selected.

Cain's City

Genesis 4:17 Instructor's Translation

And he built a city, and he called the name of the city, according to the name of his son, "dedicated" (Heb. *khanok* /חֲנוֹךְ).

There are multiple clues that this city is a negative, or at least highly ambiguous, development. After God's declaration of protection over Cain, Cain leaves Eden and provides his own form of protection by means of a city (a walled collection of homes). The building of the first city, then, is a display of Cain's lack of trust in Yahweh's ability to "be his keeper."

This city protects the murderer Cain, much like the later cities of refuge ([Num. 35:6-15](#)). And after multiple generations, Khanok will become the kind of place that protects an even more heinous murderer, Lemek.

In the literary design of Genesis 1-11, Cain's city corresponds to the building of the city of Babylon, which is also a negative development. Perhaps Cain's act is one of defiance. He has had enough of nomadic life. He refuses to abide under God's terms any longer. The only other reference to building a city in Genesis 1-11 is the incident at Babel.

"Come, let us build ourselves a city ...' (11:4). Here the whole city-building, tower-erecting project is one that God condemns ... Cain's act of city building is an attempt to provide security for himself, a security he

is not sure that God’s mark guarantees. In the words of J. Ellul, Cain ‘wants to find alone the remedy for a situation he created, but which he cannot himself repair because it is a situation dependent on God’s grace.’”

Hamilton, Victor P. (1990). [*The Book of Genesis \(New International Commentary on the Old Testament Series\) 1-17*](#). Eerdmans.

Genesis 3 and 4 As Mirror Stories

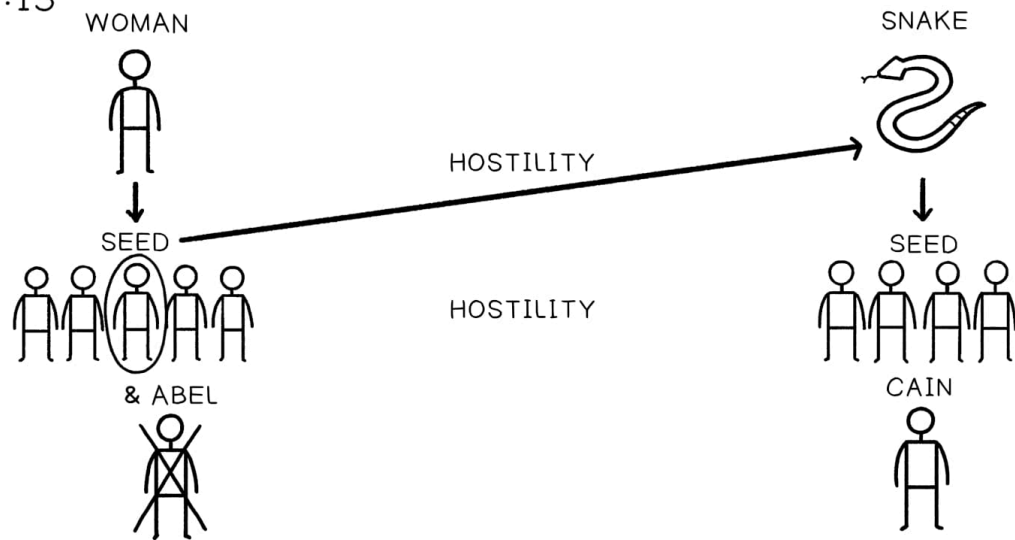
The story of Cain’s murder has been designed as a mirror that develops and intensifies the story of his parents’ failure inside of Eden.

Theme	Genesis 2-3: Adam & Eve	Genesis 4: Cain and Abel
Human given a significant choice about “good”	2:14: “from any tree of the garden you may eat, but from the tree of knowing good and evil you should not eat, because the day you eat from it you will surely die.	4:5-6: But Yahweh did not regard Cain’s offering, and Cain was very angry... Yahweh said “Why are you angry, and why has your face fallen? Isn’t it the case that if you do good, you will be lifted up?”
Human tempted by an “animal”	3:1: “Now the snake was more crafty than any creature of the field...and he said to the woman, ‘Did God really say not to eat from any tree in the garden?’”	4:6: “But if you don’t do good, sin is crouching at the door, and its desire is for you.”
Human gives into temptation with destructive consequences	3:6: “When the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and desirable to the eyes, and desirable for gaining wisdom... she took...”	4:5: “And Cain was very angry...” [4:8] And Cain spoke to Abel his brother and while they were in the field Cain rose up against Abel his brother and murdered him”
God shows up to ask a leading question	3:9: “And God called out to the human, and said “Where are you (מה איכה)?”	4:9: “And God said to Cain, “where is your (אי) brother Abel?”
	3:12: “And God said to the woman, ‘What have you done?’ (מה עשית)	4:10: “And God said, “What have you done?” (מה עשית)
Genesis 3 and 4 as Mirror Stories. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).		

Theme	Genesis 2-3: Adam & Eve	Genesis 4: Cain and Abel
Human dodges the question	3:12: "The human said 'The woman who you set with me, she gave to me and I ate.'"	4:9: "I don't know! Am I my brother's keeper?"
The perpetrator is cursed	3:14: "God said to the serpent, 'Because you have done this, you are cursed from every beast and from every creature of the field'"	4:11: "And now you are cursed from the ground..."
Inverted Desire	3:16: "Your desire will be toward your husband, and he will rule you."	4:7: "Sin...its desire is toward you, and you will rule it."
Working the ground will now be more difficult	3:17b: "in pain you will eat from the ground"	4:12: "For you will work the ground, and it will no longer give its strength to you."
	3:23: "And God sent him from the garden of Eden to work the ground"	
The human is banished from the divine presence	3:24: "And [God] banished the human and he camped east of the garden of Eden..."	4:14: "Behold, you have banished me from the face of the ground and from your presence." ... [4:16] "And Cain settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden."
Genesis 3 and 4 as Mirror Stories. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).		

Illustration: Cain Becomes the Seed of the Snake

GENESIS 3:15



Tale of Two Seeds. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Reflection Question

Biologically, Cain is “the seed of the woman,” but he becomes “the seed of the snake” by his choices. Based on this, does bloodline determine faithfulness? What can we expect from chosen families or chosen individuals in the rest of the Hebrew Bible?